

Introduction to International Relations

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Overview: This course introduces undergraduate students to the study of international politics. The core questions of the course are as follows: why do states compete with one another when cooperation offers the possibility of mutual benefit? Are democracies more peaceable than other states? Under what conditions does international competition lead to war? Have nuclear weapons transformed international politics? And how can the United States address contemporary challenges?

The course revolves primarily around problems in international security, though themes in international political economy are also examined. We will examine how the structure of the international system and domestic institutions shape states' intentions, how states convert social resources into military capabilities, and how strategic interaction among states produces outcomes including alliances, arms races, nuclear proliferation, and war.

Requirements: Completion of all assigned readings and lecture attendance is essential for your success in this course.

In-class midterm (week 7): multiple choice, short answer, and essay. 30% of course grade.

In-class final exam: multiple choice, short answer, and essay. 30% of course grade.

Cause of war essay 1 (Week 5): Select a twentieth- or twenty-first century war that is *not* one of the world wars, the invasion of Iraq, or the invasion of Ukraine. Write an essay explaining the cause of the war, drawing on your own research and the scholarship covered in the course thus far. Be sure to consider at least two competing perspectives. 5 pages, double-spaced. 15% of your grade, based on the written essay and a meeting with your instructor following the submission of the essay. More detailed guidelines circulated separately.

Cause of war essay 2 (Week 11): Re-assess the argument in your first essay in light of the theoretical scholarship on the causes of war discussed in Weeks 8 and 9 of the course. It is encouraged to change your mind and draw on new evidence. 5 pages, double-spaced. 15% of your grade, based on the written essay and a meeting with your instructor following the submission of the essay. More detailed guidelines circulated separately.

Participation: active participation in class is expected and is worth 10% of your course grade. In this course, we will uphold the university's code of conduct and values regarding open intellectual inquiry and equal respect for all class members.

Prerequisites: None.

Electronic devices: Laptops are permitted for note-taking and for referring to course readings. Please be conscious of the fact that browsing the internet during class is distracting

for the students sitting around you. If you plan to browse the internet during class time, expect to be called upon!

Plagiarism: Plagiarism is a serious breach of the University's code of conduct. It is assumed that you have carefully reviewed the University's policy on plagiarism. Your use of AI must adhere to the university's policy. Please note that you are unlikely to succeed on the midterm and final exam if you have not studied the readings in detail and thought about them yourself. Likewise, you need to be able to display ownership over the ideas expressed in your essays in our one-on-one meetings to receive a high grade. This will be considerably easier if you have written the essay yourself.

Accessibility: The University is committed to equal access for students with disabilities. Students with disabilities who have been approved to receive academic accommodations by the University must contact me as soon as possible so that the relevant accommodations can be made.

Week 1: What international relations is about (2 lectures). What are we trying to explain through the study of international politics? How does international politics differ from domestic politics?

Thucydides. *Peloponnesian War*. Ed. Robert Strassler. New York: Free Press, 1996 (selections).

Hobbes, Thomas. *Leviathan*. Ed. Richard Tuck. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996 (selections).

Week 2: Understanding anarchy (2 lectures). Is the structure of the international system sufficient to explain interstate competition and conflict? Do state intentions matter?

Jervis, Robert. "Cooperation under the security dilemma." *World Politics* 30.2 (1978): 167-214.

Powell, Robert. "Absolute and relative gains in international relations theory." *American Political Science Review* 85.4 (1991): 1303-1320.

Schweller, Randall. "Neorealism's status-quo bias: What security dilemma?" *Security Studies* 5.3 (1996): 90-121.

Week 3: Where states' intentions come from (2 lectures). How do domestic interests shape states' foreign policy goals? How do actors come to understand their interests?

Moravcsik, Andrew. "Taking preferences seriously: A liberal theory of international politics." *International Organization* 51.4 (1997): 513-553.

Snyder, Jack. *Myths of Empire: Domestic Politics and International Ambition*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1991 (selections).

Finnemore, Martha, and Kathryn Sikkink. "Taking stock: the constructivist research program in international relations and comparative politics." *Annual Review of Political Science* 4.1 (2001): 391-416.

Week 4: Domestic constraints on international cooperation. In what ways do domestic interests constrain states' ability to pursue mutual gains through international cooperation? How do institutions affect which interests matter?

Keohane, Robert. *After Hegemony: Cooperation and Discord in the World Political Economy*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1984 (selections).

Putnam, Robert. "Diplomacy and Domestic Politics: The Logic of Two-Level Games." *International Organization* 42.3 (1988): 427-460.

Milner, Helen. *Interests, Institutions, and Information: Domestic Politics and International Relations*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1997 (selections).

Week 5: Domestic regime types and intentions. Do democracies have systematically different foreign policy intentions than non-democracies? Does the influence of the mass public lead to more peaceable or more aggressive policy?

Weeks, Jessica. "Strongmen and Straw Men: Authoritarian Regimes and the Initiation of International Conflict." *American Political Science Review* 106.2 (2012): 326-347.

Rosato, Sebastian. "The flawed logic of democratic peace theory." *American Political Science Review* 97.4 (2003): 585-602.

von Clausewitz, Carl. *On War*. Trans. Peter Paret. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1989 (selections).

Ferejohn, John, and Frances Rosenbluth. *Forged Through Fire: War, Peace, and the Democratic Bargain*. New York: W.W. Norton, 2016 (selections).

Week 6: From intentions to capabilities (2 lectures). Under what conditions are states able to develop the military power necessary to achieve foreign policy goals? How do domestic institutions affect military capabilities?

Cox, Gary, and Mark Dincecco. "The budgetary origins of fiscal-military prowess." *Journal of Politics* 83.3 (2021): 851-866.

Seligmann, Matthew. "The Anglo-German Naval Race, 1898-1914." In *Arms Races in International Politics: From the Nineteenth to the Twenty-First Century*, ed. Thomas Mahnken. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2016.

Talmadge, Caitlin. *The Dictator's Army: Battlefield Effectiveness in Authoritarian Regimes*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 2015 (selections).

Week 7: Responses to foreign threats (2 lectures). How do states perceive and respond to threats from other states? When do they balance against potential opponents through alliances?

Yarhi-Milo, Keren. *Knowing the Adversary: Leaders, Intelligence, and Assessment of Intentions in International Relations*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2014 (selections).

Walt, Stephen. *The Origins of Alliances*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1987.

Trubowitz, Peter, and Peter Harris. “When states appease: British appeasement in the 1930s.” *Review of International Studies* 41.2 (2015): 289-311.

Week 8: Causes of War, Part I (2 lectures). Why are conflicting interests an insufficient explanation for the outbreak of war? How can information asymmetries about capabilities and resolve lead to war, and how might these asymmetries explain the outbreak of war in 1914?

Fearon, James. “Rationalist explanations for war.” *International Organization* 49.3 (1995): 379-414.

Clark, Christopher. *The Sleepwalkers: How Europe Went to War in 1914*. New York: Harper, 2014 (selections).

Week 9: Causes of War, Part II (2 lectures). Under what conditions might a declining power choose to initiate war with a rising adversary? Can the logic of preventive war explain the outbreak of war in 1914 or Russia’s invasion of Ukraine in 2022?

Fearon, James. “Rationalist explanations for war.” *International Organization* 49.3 (1995): 379-414.

Levy, Jack, and William Mulligan. “Shifting Power, Preventive Logic, and the Response of the Target: Germany, Russia, and the First World War,” *Journal of Strategic Studies* 40. 5 (2017): 731–769.

Posen, Barry. “Putin’s Preventive War: The 2022 Invasion of Ukraine.” *International Security* 49.3 (Winter 2024/25): 7–49.

Week 10: Nuclear weapons (2 lectures). In what sense have nuclear weapons transformed international politics? Is conventional military force irrelevant in interactions between nuclear states? Is it rational for states to aspire to victory in nuclear war?

Freedman, Lawrence. *The Evolution of Nuclear Strategy*. London: Springer, 2019 (selections).

Jervis, Robert. *The Meaning of the Nuclear Revolution: Statecraft and the Prospect of Armageddon*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1989 (selections).

Lieber, Keir, and Daryl Press. *The Myth of the Nuclear Revolution: Power Politics in the Atomic Age*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 2020 (selections).

Week 11: The unipolar moment and the post-Cold War order (2 lectures). How did the collapse of the Soviet Union change international politics? Did the United States make proper use of its ‘unipolar moment,’ or are today’s problems a reflection of strategic errors in the 1990s?

Ikenberry, John. *After Victory: Institutions, Strategic Restraint, and the Rebuilding of Order after Major Wars*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2001 (selections).

Rodrik, Dani. *The Globalization Paradox: Democracy and the Future of the World Economy*. New York: W.W. Norton, 2011 (selections).

Haslam, Jonathan. *Hubris The Origins of Russia’s War Against Ukraine*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2025 (selections).

Week 12: Nuclear proliferation (2 lectures). Why do states pursue nuclear weapons in the contemporary world? Under what conditions do states undertake preventive war against potential proliferators? Does nuclear proliferation lead to greater international stability or instability?

Sagan, Scott. “Why do states build nuclear weapons?: Three models in search of a bomb.” *International security* 21.3 (1996): 54-86.

Debs, Alexandre, and Nuno P. Monteiro. “Known unknowns: Power shifts, uncertainty, and war.” *International Organization* 68.1 (2014): 1-31.

Brands, Hal, and David Palkki. “Saddam, Israel, and the Bomb: Nuclear Alarmism Justified?” *International Security* 36.1 (2011): 133-166.

Week 13: Dealing with the end of unipolarity (2 lectures). How should the United States respond to the rise of new powers? Is restraint a viable strategy? What are the prospects of successful accommodation?

Posen, Barry. *Restraint: A New Foundation for U.S. Grand Strategy*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 2015 (selections).

Meijer, Hugo and Stephen Brooks. “Illusions of Autonomy: Why Europe Cannot Provide for Its Security If the United States Pulls Back.” *International Security* 45.4 (2021): 7-43.

Michael Beckley. “The Peril of Peaking Powers: Economic Slowdowns and Implications for China’s Next Decade.” *International Security* 48.1 (2023): 7-46.